Where You Are: Step One, Your Family's Care Situation, and What Comes After It

The whole road in nine steps, with yours marked.

Planning ahead can feel like a job with no edges. It has an order, and you're at the very start of it: step one of nine, with no clock on any of them.

Below is the whole road, with your place marked and a few lines on what follows.

Phase 1 · Care Assessment

Understand the person, the family, and the situation.

1 **Discover** Current Situation → Concerns & Challenges → Goals & Priorities
You finish with: Family Care Starting Profile

You are here. This step begins with the topic you're on: your family's current care situation. Your part of it is done when a written summary of how things work for Mom today exists, the family knows where it is kept, and you've named a date or a kind of change that would bring you back to it.

2 **Assess** Health & Function → Safety & Support → Lifestyle & Preferences
You finish with: Personal Care Baseline and Preferences Profile

3 **Define Needs** Needs & Risks → Care Requirements → Priorities & Recommendations
You finish with: Care Needs Profile and Future Action Roadmap

Phase 2 · Care Planning

Determine what good care should look like and prepare to put it in place.

4 **Explore Options** Care Setting → Provider/Facility Fit → Selection & Decision
You finish with: Preliminary Care Options Research and Decision Plan

5 **Build the Plan** Health & Personal Care → Daily Life & Quality of Life → Monitoring & Response
You finish with: Personal Care Planning File and Future Review Templates

6 **Prepare the Transition** Preparation → Move & Admission → Continuity of Care
You finish with: Transition-Readiness File and Future Handoff Template

Phase 3 · Care Management

Coordinate the plan, review what happens, and prepare the family to take the lead.

7 **Coordinate** People & Responsibilities → Communication & Handoffs → Care-Plan Alignment
You finish with: Care Team, Communication, and Meeting-Readiness Kit

8 **Monitor** Monitor → Identify & Escalate → Review & Adjust
You finish with: Monitoring, Advocacy, and Review-Readiness Kit

9 **Hand Off** Educate → Empower → Support

You finish with: Starter Family Care Playbook and Future Support Plan

What this step produces

A written picture of how Mom's week works today: where she lives, what a typical day looks like, who helps and what each person actually does, and what the family doesn't know yet. These are the family's own notes, put in order. Nobody is being assessed, and nothing on the page calls for a change.

It can be short. AARP says of a family's plan that it doesn't have to be extensive or fancy, and that holds for this page too. [1]

What happens next

Two more topics finish step one: the family's concerns and challenges, and then goals and priorities. The picture you write now is what both of them start from. Together the three make up what the roadmap calls the Family Care Starting Profile.

If your family goes on with your care consultant, this first topic has two parts: an optional first intake, then a family interview that documents the current arrangement and what a typical day looks like, and looks at who is doing what.

After that comes step two, Assess. The rest of the road is there when your family wants it.

Who is involved, by role

The Family Caregiver Alliance counts everyone who is or will be part of the helping as the team, and that may include a family friend, a neighbor or a paid caregiver. [2]

- Mom: her own account of her week. She sees the page and can correct it.
- You and your family: asking, listing, writing down and comparing notes.
- The people who help, such as your sister and the neighbor: what each of them actually does.
- Her doctor and her other clinicians: any question about her health.
- With your care consultant: the family interview, including whether one person is carrying most of the work.

What this page doesn't promise

How long any step takes, who will be available, or how anything turns out. A family planning ahead sets its own pace, and can stop after any step.

Ready for the next step?

You've seen the whole road and your place on it. The care interview is one way to take this first step: it goes through Mom's daily life a part at a time, notes what is still incomplete, and builds a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The nine steps are the Family Care Roadmap's own. The remark that a plan doesn't have to be fancy is AARP's, and the description of who belongs on the team is the Family Caregiver Alliance's.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting